Questions for product managers

Design Gurus

Three questions a product manager should expect, in the same format as the earlier chapters.

Question 1: Tell me about a time you had to influence a team you had no authority over.

Intention of the question: Product managers deliver through people who do not report to them. The interviewer wants to see how you moved work you could not assign.

Pitfalls to avoid: Avoid a story where you escalated and somebody senior made them do it. Do not describe influence as charm or relationship building. Say what evidence or what trade you brought.

Sample Answer 1:

Situation: "I was the product manager for a checkout flow used by about 90,000 customers a week. Conversion dropped 4 percent after a redesign. The team that owned the payment step reported to a different director and had their own committed goals."

Task: "I needed two of their engineers for about three weeks. I could not assign the work and their quarter was already planned. Their director had no reason to care about my metric."

Action: "I stopped asking for people and went to find out what the change would do for them. Their on-call load was mostly failed payment retries, around 40 pages a month. The same fix removed most of those. So I rewrote the request as a shared problem and brought both numbers to their director. Four percent of conversion for us, about 30 fewer pages a month for them. I also offered something concrete. I would write the customer-facing copy and run the rollout communication myself. That took roughly a week of work off their plate."

Result: "They gave me two engineers for two sprints. Conversion recovered to within 1 percent of the old flow. Their payment pages fell from about 40 a month to 11. What I learned is that influence without authority is mostly research. I had spent two weeks asking, and about two hours finding the reason they would say yes."

Sample Answer 2: "A smaller version of the same thing. I needed a data team to change an event schema they considered stable. Rather than argue for it, I spent one afternoon building the report I wanted on their existing schema. Three of its five columns came out empty. I showed them the broken report instead of describing the problem. They proposed the schema change themselves the next day. Showing somebody the consequence works better than describing it, and it hands them the decision rather than taking it."

Follow-up you should expect: "What would you have done if their director had said no?"

Why they ask: Influence stories almost always end in a yes. They want to know whether you had a plan for the other outcome, or whether your next step was to escalate.

How to answer it: "I would have asked what would need to be true for it to be a yes next

quarter. Then I would have written that down. Then I would have shipped the smaller version we could do alone. That was a copy change worth maybe a third of the conversion. I had that scoped before the meeting. Escalating to my own director was available and I would not have used it. I needed that team again three months later."

Question 2: Tell me about a product decision you got wrong.

Intention of the question: Every product manager has shipped something that failed. The interviewer wants to know whether you noticed, how quickly, and what you changed in how you decide.

Pitfalls to avoid: Avoid a failure caused entirely by engineering or by the market. Do not choose something you killed before launch, because that costs nothing. Say what the decision cost and who paid for it.

Sample Answer 1:

Situation: "I decided to build a bulk import feature for our onboarding flow. Our three largest customers had asked for it, and I had a count of support tickets that seemed to support it. It took a team of four about ten weeks."

Task: "I owned the roadmap slot. Taking those ten weeks meant not doing the mobile onboarding work, which was the alternative on the table."

Action: "It launched and about 2 percent of new accounts used it in the first quarter. I had counted tickets mentioning imports, but I had never checked who filed them. Almost all came from those three accounts, or from our own support team on their behalf. I said so in the quarterly review rather than letting it sit quietly. I wrote up what I would check in future, which is distinct accounts rather than ticket volume. Then I asked for four weeks to ship a cut-down version of the mobile work we had skipped."

Result: "Mobile onboarding shipped a quarter late and lifted activation by about 11 percent. The import feature moved activation by less than a point. The import feature is still there and still used by three customers. The rule I took from it is that demand counted in tickets is demand counted in the loudest voices. I now count distinct accounts before anything reaches a roadmap."

Sample Answer 2: "I got a smaller one wrong in the opposite direction. I killed a feature after two weeks of low usage, and it turned out the entry point sat three clicks deep in a menu. Almost nobody had rejected it. Almost nobody had found it. I now check whether something was discoverable before I conclude it was unwanted, which is usually an afternoon of session recordings rather than a decision."

Follow-up you should expect: "You said you counted tickets. Who else signed off on that decision?"

Why they ask: They want to know whether you keep the responsibility or spread it across the people who approved you.

How to answer it: "My director and the engineering lead both approved it. But I brought them the same flawed number, so their approval was only ever as good as my analysis. The decision was mine. What I changed is that our roadmap document now has a line for how demand was measured. The next reviewer can challenge the method rather than only the conclusion."

Question 3: Tell me about a time you had to say no to an important stakeholder.

Intention of the question: Whether you can decline without damaging the relationship, and whether your reason goes beyond not having capacity.

Pitfalls to avoid: Avoid a no that was really somebody else's decision. Do not describe the stakeholder as unreasonable. Say what you offered instead of the thing you refused.

Sample Answer 1:

Situation: "Our largest customer, worth about 18 percent of revenue, asked for a custom reporting view. Our head of sales supported the request. The build was around six weeks."

Task: "The decision was mine. Six weeks was the whole quarter's discretionary capacity, and the request served one account."

Action: "I did not argue about priority. I asked our sales lead one question: how many other customers had asked for something similar. The answer was two, and both wanted something different. So I proposed a smaller thing. A data export all three could use, about a week of work, plus a call where I walked their analyst through building the view themselves. I said plainly that a custom view for one account was something I was not going to build, and gave the reason. We had done exactly that twice before and both were still on our maintenance list two years later."

Result: "They took the export. It shipped in eight days and the customer renewed. The other two accounts used it within a month. What made the no work was having a number for the cost of saying yes. It came from our own history rather than from an opinion about focus."

Sample Answer 2: "Sometimes the no has to be plainer than that. An executive asked me for a dashboard for a board meeting in two days. I said no, and offered a screenshot with the three numbers he actually needed, which took me forty minutes. He used the screenshot. A no with something concrete attached lands very differently from a no with only a reason attached."

Follow-up you should expect: "What if your head of sales had escalated over you?"

Why they ask: They want to know what you do when the no does not hold, which is the more common outcome.

How to answer it: "Then it becomes a resourcing conversation rather than a product one, and it should. I would have asked for the six weeks to be added rather than substituted. I would also have been explicit about what would not ship if it was substituted. If the decision still came back the other way, I would have built it. I would also have written down what it would cost us to maintain, so the next request of that shape had a real number attached. Losing that argument once is fine. Losing it silently is what makes it happen every quarter."